

Analyzing Coursera's AI Foundations: Prompt Engineering with ChatGPT Course

For this assignment, I evaluated the Coursera course *AI Foundations: Prompt Engineering with ChatGPT* offered by Arizona State University. My analysis focuses on how the course environment supports or hinders learner engagement, access, and success, with particular attention to Universal Design for Learning (UDL) and the Accessibility Layer framework. I also used the WAVE Web Accessibility Evaluation Tool, which returned an AIM score of 10 out of 10, to inform the accessibility portion of this review.

Strengths: Engagement, Access, and Support

Course layout and navigation

Coursera's course layout is a clear strength. The left navigation pane provides consistent access to core elements such as Course Material, Grades, Notes, Discussion Forums, Messages, and Course Info, which helps learners quickly locate what they need without unnecessary searching. In the central course area, modules are presented in a logical sequence.

Learning plan and timeline tools

On the right side of the interface, Coursera offers a Learning Plan feature. This structure gives learners a transparent view of expectations and progress, which aligns with UDL's focus on supporting self-regulation and goal-setting.

Based on the learning plan, Coursera generates a course timeline that projects assignment deadlines and a course end date. These tools promote planning, time management, and persistence, supporting UDL's emphasis on scaffolding executive functioning and engagement.

Barriers: Potential Exclusion or Disadvantage

Limited captioning and visibility of transcripts

Course videos do not include captions, and the only accessible text alternative is the transcript placed below the video. On some devices, especially when learners view content in full-screen mode or on smaller screens, the transcript is not immediately visible. There is also no clear on-screen note indicating that the transcript is available. For learners who are deaf or hard of hearing, or who prefer to read along, this design can create a significant accessibility barrier.

Limited instructor presence

Because the course is fully online and asynchronous, learners may feel isolated. While the content and activities are well organized, visible signs of instructor presence (such as regular announcements, Q&A sessions, or personalized feedback) are limited. Without explicit instructor engagement, some learners may struggle with motivation, feel less supported, or be unsure where to turn when they encounter challenges.

Mobile optimization gaps

In my testing, the course adjusted to mobile screen size but some module elements were not fully optimized for mobile use. Coursera sometimes displays a clear message prompting the learner to switch to a laptop or desktop to view certain content. For learners who rely on mobile-only access, this introduces friction and may block participation in parts of the course. Even when the core content is technically available, inconsistent mobile experiences can undermine equitable access.

Recommendations for improvement linked to UDL and the Accessibility Layer

Add captions and clearer transcript cues to all course videos and include a brief on-screen note or icon indicating that a full transcript with timestamps appears below the video.

Rationale and framework connection:

This change directly supports UDL's **multiple means of representation** by providing equivalent access for learners who cannot or prefer not to rely on audio. It also aligns with the **Accessibility Layer** emphasis on ensuring that content is **perceivable** across different sensory preferences and needs. Even though the WAVE score is high, captions would address a deeper layer of pedagogical accessibility that automated tools do not fully capture.

Increase mobile responsiveness and consistency

Recommendation: Work toward full mobile optimization so that all modules and activities can be viewed and completed on a phone or tablet, without requiring a switch to a desktop or laptop.

Rationale and framework connection:

Because Coursera learners engage from around the world and often “on the go,” consistent mobile functionality is critical for **equitable access**. This improvement supports UDL's **engagement** principle by reducing logistical barriers that can derail participation, and it strengthens the Accessibility Layer's focus on **flexible access points**.

When the experience is consistent across devices, learners can better sustain focus, motivation, and progress.

Clarify overall course objectives and align the final assignment

Recommendation: Add a set of **explicit, course-level learning objectives** that connect the individual module objectives to the **final summative activity** (e.g., the optional “Your Best Prompt” assignment). Clarify how each module builds toward those overarching outcomes.

Rationale and framework connection:

Right now, each module lists learning objectives, but the **overall course objectives are not clearly stated**. Making the course-level goals visible would help learners understand how activities fit together and why the final assignment matters. This supports UDL’s emphasis on **clear goals, expectations, and scaffolding** under both **Engagement** and **Action & Expression**. It also makes it easier for learners to self-assess their growth and decide how deeply to engage with optional tasks.

Visible instructor presence and engagement

Recommendation: Structured instructor presence, such as, short **instructor video or written summaries** at the end of each module. Occasional **instructor-graded checkpoints** or rubric-based spot checks of peer reviews. Periodic **announcements or Q&A opportunities** (e.g., discussion board threads)

Rationale and framework connection:

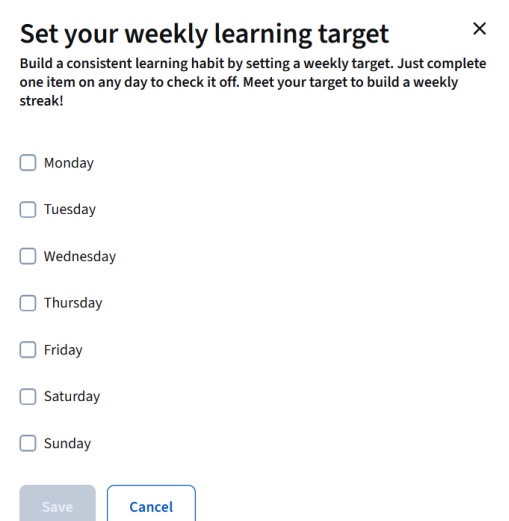
These adjustments would preserve the benefits of peer learning while reducing perceived bias and uncertainty. They align with UDL’s **Engagement** guidelines about fostering **relevance, collaboration, and community**, as well as the Accessibility Layer’s focus on **social and emotional access**. Instructor presence can also help mitigate feelings of isolation common in fully online, asynchronous environments.

References

- Arizona State University. (2026). Coursera. Online Courses.™. Credentials From Top Educators; Join for Free. Coursera. Coursera. <https://www.coursera.org/learn/ai-foundations-prompt-engineering-with-chatgpt/home/info>
- DeCuir, PhD, R. (2026). Module 7 Resources; Why Digital Learning Matters. Lsu.edu. <https://moodle.lsu.edu/mod/book/view.php?id=3651843&chapterid=614262>
- WebAIM (Web Accessibility in Mind). (1996). WebAIM; WebAIM's WCAG 2.1 Checklist. Webaim.org. <https://webaim.org/standards/wcag/checklist#sc1.3.1>

Appendix

Screenshots of weekly learning target and course timeline within a Coursera module to help track progress:



Set your weekly learning target ×

Build a consistent learning habit by setting a weekly target. Just complete one item on any day to check it off. Meet your target to build a weekly streak!

- ☐ Monday
- ☐ Tuesday
- ☐ Wednesday
- ☐ Thursday
- ☐ Friday
- ☐ Saturday
- ☐ Sunday

Figure 1: Coursera Learning Plan Example

Learning plan

I'm committed to learning 5 days a week on Coursera.

MTWTFSS

[Edit my learning plan](#)

Course timeline

Time to regain momentum!

You're behind schedule. Let's focus on one small achievable step you can take today to start catching up. You can do it!

📍 Start date: January 22, 2025

Your next two deadlines

[Use RACCCA to Evaluate Prompt Responses](#)

Overdue Peer-graded Assignment

[Constraint-Based Prompt Engineering](#)

Due today by 11:59 PM CDT Peer-graded Assignment

📅 Estimated end date: March 28, 2026

Figure 2: Coursera Course Timeline Screenshot